

FutureYou: How Existing Organization Shapes Experienced Possibilities and Subsequent Encounters

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Abstract

An available alternative need not become a spontaneously demonstrated candidate, and a personally familiar choice need not establish what another person regards as reasonable. These differences matter when they affect subsequent encounters rather than only immediate preference or performance. This article develops a cross-domain inferential synthesis asking how existing personal organization, material opportunity, option generation, and interpersonal interpretation jointly condition future information contact and experienced possibility. It integrates established ecological affordance, consideration-set, option-generation, active-sampling, and social-projection research without proposing a new mechanism or claiming exclusive theoretical originality. Illustrative utensil and social-choice encounters distinguish demonstrable nonmention from inferred private nonconsideration, prompted recognition from spontaneous generation, personal fit from perceived legitimacy for others, and requested from delivered information. A prospective research program specifies matched alternative cues, delayed unprompted transfer, separate information-delivery interventions, and a factorial study independently randomizing an earlier personal-task cue and a later other-person choice. Its primary estimand is their intention-to-treat interaction on privately requested explanation, with conventional priming, support-theory, and skilled-intentionality accounts retained as plausible explanations. Null and equivalence outcomes explicitly contract the proposed bridge. No new participant data are reported. The intended contribution is a testable

composition concerning human experiential and informational opportunity, not a universal learning rule, a consciousness-specific process, or a causal account inferred from behavior alone.

Keywords: affordances; option generation; consideration sets; social inference; information seeking; human experience

1. Introduction: everyday possibility and the scientific question

Familiar encounters

A person reaches into a drawer and selects a small spoon. The larger spoons are beside it, visible and usable. Yet the action may not feel like choosing among sizes. The hand goes to the familiar item, and eating begins. Asked afterward, the person might say the larger spoons are uncomfortable, or might only then notice that the drawer contains alternatives. A question about choice has arisen where, during the original encounter, no explicit choice may have been experienced. Another person might reach for the larger spoon just as naturally. The objects are in the same drawer, but the candidates that matter to each person need not be the same.

A typist uses a preferred mechanical keyboard. The key travel, resistance, sound, and timing feel ordinary. A different switch can make the familiar action conspicuous: the typist becomes aware of each stroke or thinks someone else's preference is inexplicable. A favorite pen produces a similar case on a smaller scale. Someone can understand that other pens write perfectly well while never considering them when packing a bag. An alternative can be recognized, usable, and judged acceptable in general without being experienced as a candidate for oneself.

The examples can also turn outward. A person who feels that a keyboard should have a tactile click may interpret another person's preference for silent switches as strange or misguided. Someone who always wears a watch on one wrist may regard the other wrist as wrong, even when discussing another person's body. People have preferences for boxers or briefs, utensils, writing instruments, drinks, and information sources; those familiar experiences can become informal standards for judging what other people do. Such judgments are not inevitable. They may be restrained by recognizing different sensory needs,

knowledge, cultural practices, or purposes. The phenomenon worth examining is the possible transfer from **what feels normal for me** to **what appears sensible or normal for someone else**.

These examples do not prove that preferences were acquired unconsciously. Nor are preferences the principal phenomenon the paper seeks to explain. They are an accessible way to recognize a deeper contrast: something can be materially present and even recognizable without being considered as an option; something can be considered without being experienced as reasonable; and a personally familiar response can become an implicit reference for interpreting another person. Each contrast can affect what information, people, and opportunities the individual encounters next.

From available world to demonstrated consideration

The environment presents objects, information, other people, and possible activities. Human experience does not necessarily present every element as equally relevant. People notice selectively, generate candidates under constraints, anticipate different consequences, and respond through habits, learned practices, bodily conditions, goals, and social expectations. The person's current organization is not imposed from outside the person on an otherwise neutral consciousness; it is part of the conditions of perceiving, evaluating, acting, and experiencing.

The statement that two people live in different 'realities' can be useful in ordinary conversation but is scientifically ambiguous. This article does **not** propose that objectively different physical worlds are created by a preference, or that every individual report is equally accurate about public facts. It concerns **different experienced fields of relevance and possibility within a partially shared environment**. An object may be physically accessible to two people, but only one anticipates using it; an explanation may be publicly available, but only one person recognizes it as a path worth pursuing. Differences in skills and circumstances can also make the affordance genuinely different, not merely differently noticed. The design must specify which claim is being made.

Three scientifically different situations are often compressed into a statement like 'I never saw that as an option.' First, the person may not have perceptually detected the alternative. Second, the person may have

detected and recognized it, but not generated it as a candidate for the present goal. Third, the person may have generated it as a candidate and rejected it as irrelevant, undesirable, impossible, or improper. The person's later description alone cannot always establish which occurred. The experimenter must not infer an unconscious absence of consideration from a missing verbal report.

A fourth situation becomes important once other people enter the scene. Someone may correctly understand that an alternative is available and useful to another person while still finding it unappealing personally. Someone else may judge that the alternative is not reasonable *for anyone*, treating their own response as a standard of normality. These are not identical judgments. An unfamiliar preference can also be judged negatively for reasons unrelated to egocentric projection: safety, cost, perceived competence, social rules, or information about another person's constraints. Those explanations must remain possible rather than presuming that social disagreement is always a failure of perspective-taking.

The scientific question is therefore:

How does the current organization of a person condition which possibilities become noticeable, viable, experientially significant, or legitimate in an encounter; how can those conditions affect interpretation of other people's choices; and how do the resulting actions and omissions alter the information and situations available in subsequent encounters?

The initial preference is a background condition or useful experimental contrast, not an outcome whose developmental history must be reconstructed. Its consequences can appear without a change in the preference itself. A person can keep preferring small utensils yet begin recognizing large utensils as valid possibilities for other people. Someone can continue preferring hands-on learning while newly considering a book when a particular problem arises. Someone can dislike another keyboard but stop interpreting its user as irrational. Each case changes the organization of the next encounter while preserving the original taste or habit.

The account is human-experience-centered rather than an optimization theory. A possibility can matter because it feels meaningful, normal, alien, interesting, improper, or personally fitting, independently of whether it improves speed, accuracy, survival, or external reward. Performance, utility, and correctness

can still be measured when they answer a particular question. They are not prerequisites for a reported experiential consequence to count as an outcome.

The overarching relationship is temporal but not rigidly sequential. Existing dispositions condition encounters; encounters can reveal, exercise, reinforce, question, or leave those dispositions unchanged; activity and inaction determine what is sampled or missed next. During a single ongoing task, a newly recognized possibility can alter what the person does before any experimenter-defined episode ends. Over repeated encounters, differences in what is considered can generate diverging histories of information and experience. The aim is to explain these relationships with existing science and test them without inferring a hidden route from a single endpoint.

2. Established theories and the strongest neighboring explanations

Experiential continuity and embodied history

Dewey's critique of an isolated reflex arc treats perception and action as parts of a developing coordination, rather than unrelated stimulus and response events (Dewey, 1896). His later account of experiential continuity argues that an encounter can affect the dispositions through which subsequent experiences occur (Dewey, 1938). FutureYou's basic temporal premise is already present in this historical account: the person who next encounters the world does not do so under circumstances independent of previous experience.

Grounded cognition similarly rejects an account of situated responses as isolated symbolic decisions unrelated to perception, bodily action, and introspective activity. Barsalou (2008, 2009) describes how situationally patterned experience may influence conceptual processing and prediction. This provides a powerful established way to interpret why an instrument, book, drink, or social act can call forth familiar expectations. The paper does not introduce an alternative brain system to compete with these accounts.

The landscape and the lived field of affordances

Gibson's ecological concept of an affordance concerns possibilities for action in the relation between a living being and its environment (Gibson, 1979). Rietveld and Kiverstein (2014) develop the **rich landscape of affordances**, emphasizing the person's skills and sociocultural form of life. Van Dijk and Rietveld's (2017) Skilled Intentionality Framework is especially close to the present paper because it connects sociomaterial practices, the landscape of affordances, and an individual's lived **field of relevant affordances** in ongoing activity. This is not merely a theory of movement toward objects; it explicitly addresses meaningful social participation.

Baggs and Chemero (2021) argue that ecological and enactive accounts offer complementary directions of embodied explanation. Their synthesis reinforces the importance of not treating an organism's internal representation as the sole cause of an experienced world. Actual environmental structure, abilities, current practices, and continuing organism–environment relations must remain causally relevant. The present paper uses organism-carried organization as a declared focus, not as a denial that context and relation help determine what is possible.

Options are not simply the alternatives printed on a menu

Kalis, Kaiser, and Mojzisch (2013) make a critical distinction between the possibilities an experimenter provides and the **options generated as candidates for goal-directed action**. Standard forced-choice tasks begin with a displayed set, but everyday action often requires people to generate the candidates themselves. This is a direct precedent for the small-utensil and learning-resource examples. A researcher who asks participants to choose between a book and a demonstration has already made both candidates explicit; the procedure cannot establish whether either would have arisen spontaneously.

Selection-history research, including Anderson et al. (2021), supplies established mechanisms and functional accounts of attention influenced by prior selection, reward, and task history. Its relevance to FutureYou is straightforward: the currently selected information is partly influenced by previous experience, not solely the most salient physical stimulus or explicit current goal. This background

motivates contrasts among physical offering, perceptual detection, candidate generation, and later selection without requiring an additional integration module.

Consideration sets and the costs of considering

An available object is not automatically a considered alternative; this is also foundational in marketing and economics, not just option-generation psychology. Hauser and Wernerfelt (1990) distinguish deciding whether to evaluate a brand, including an evaluated brand in a consideration set, and eventually consuming a brand. Their evaluation-cost analysis treats consideration as economically consequential and predicts dynamic effects of information and entry into a consideration set. A claim that the small spoon and large spoon are materially present but not equally considered is therefore strongly **PRECEDENTED**. The present article adds no claim that these decision distinctions require new cognitive architecture. Aguiar, Boccardi, Kashaev, and Kim (2023) provide an even stronger methodological precedent. Their stochastic-choice and limited-consideration framework exploits variation in choice menus and attention frames to test consideration-sensitive models against random utility. Their large online experiment demonstrates why final choice distributions can be insufficient to distinguish preferences from constrained consideration. Consequently, *FutureYou* must not claim a new general identification method simply because a prompt modifies later selection. The remaining task is to connect those established contrasts to the **person's subsequent informational and interpersonal encounters**, while carefully specifying whether the observed effect is a framing, retrieval, preference, or informational change. Kaiser et al. (2013) compare option generation and subsequent choice using behavioral and fMRI tasks, reporting differences between self-generated and externally supplied options. Their work is a direct experimental predecessor. It challenges any interpretation of a new spontaneous-versus-prompted-option task as inherently original. Indeed, the ordinary failure to mention an option is less informative about the private candidate set than the experimental pattern of externally changing its availability and testing the next response. This article uses the established distinction without claiming its cognitive or neural correlates as a discovery.

Information foraging, active sampling, and self-directed learning

Pirolli and Card (1999) model how people seek and gather information across environments and informational costs. Gottlieb and Oudeyer (2018) distinguish task-oriented sampling from open-ended information search, including preferences over cognitive states and curiosity that cannot be reduced to immediate external reward. Gureckis and Markant (2012) review how learners select the information from which they learn. Markant and Gureckis (2014) directly compare active selection and passive reception of information. These are substantive predecessors for the idea that a person's current organization affects the information they encounter next.

Metacognition and the felt availability of learning routes

Nelson and Narens (1990) describe a monitoring–control architecture in which judgments about knowledge can affect subsequent study decisions. Koriat (1997) explains how judgments of learning can depend on cues that imperfectly track eventual recall. Deslauriers et al. (2019) experimentally distinguish felt learning from demonstrated learning during active versus lecture instruction. These works are necessary because an individual who feels a lecture to be sufficient may cease looking for examples, while someone who feels uncertain may search for clarification, practice, or additional sources. Importantly, uncertainty can also prompt avoidance, and experienced fluency need not determine subsequent behavior.

A preference for hands-on work is not a fixed learning-style diagnosis. Pashler et al. (2008) find inadequate evidence for the popular assumption that instruction should be matched to stable individually declared learning styles. A person can genuinely prefer one information pathway without that pathway being objectively optimal. The scientific concern here is whether another pathway becomes a candidate at all, how it is evaluated when made explicit, and what informational opportunities follow.

Social projection, perceived normality, and selective exposure

Ross, Greene, and House (1977) identify the false-consensus effect: people's own responses can influence estimates of how common a response is and what choosing differently implies about another person. This is a direct precedent for a preferred utensil, keyboard, clothing style, or drink becoming a default reference in social evaluation. One cannot infer a false-consensus bias merely because two people disagree; perceived norms, social knowledge, actual prevalence, and task framing must be assessed. Minson and Dorison (2022) review why contrary viewpoints can be aversive, including naïve realism, self-threat, and effort. Their account connects evaluations of disagreement to subsequent opportunities for exposure to conflicting information. This is particularly relevant because judgments of another person may influence whether their reasons are requested, heard, or dismissed. The social consequence thus need not be interpersonal hostility; it may be an ordinary, unremarked decision not to investigate an unfamiliar point of view.

Dorison, Minson, and Rogers (2019) provide a particularly direct precedent for a consequence beyond an initial social judgment. Across five experiments involving political disagreement, they found that people overestimated the negative feelings associated with encountering opposing viewpoints, and that correcting biased forecasts reduced selective exposure in their experimental settings. Thus, expectations about another person's perspective can already be linked experimentally to actual subsequent information-consumption choices. FutureYou does not claim that link as new. Its specific prospective comparison instead independently randomizes an earlier cue about a personally feasible alternative and a later other-person choice, then measures a private request for the person's explanation under matched conditions. A resulting interaction could still be accounted for by affective forecasting, familiar support-theory processes, or situated affordances; those explanations remain eligible competitors.

Liquin and Lombrozo (2020) studied explanation-seeking curiosity in three experiments and found that expected future learning and utility predicted curiosity beyond novelty or surprise. Thus a person's decision to seek reasons, not merely to notice disagreement, is already a substantive empirical target. This

article retains that explanation-seeking account as a competing interpretation of any private information request; the crossed earlier-personal-cue and later-other-choice assignment test is not claimed to identify a new motive for curiosity.

Direct predecessors joining preference, description, and social inference

Brenner and Bilgin (2011) directly link an individual's own preference, the salience or unpacking of alternatives, and predictions about other people's preferences using support-theory models. The paper reports that preference-dependent salience and discounting of less-preferred alternatives contribute to social projection under their experimental tasks. This establishes a much closer precedent than merely observing false consensus: changing how an alternative is described can change social prediction, and personally preferred options can resist description-based changes in salience. It would be scientifically wrong to claim that *FutureYou* first connects personal preference, option description, and judging others. The social affordance literature is also broader than the 2017 Skilled Intentionality Framework alone. Creem-Regehr et al. (2013) synthesize spatial perspective taking and perception of what *another* person can do, including when one's own capabilities become an imperfect reference for the other's. Kiverstein and Rietveld (2021) extend affordance-based explanation to social and collective intentionality and longer-term coordination. Neither contribution is simply a personal-choice account. They challenge any proposition that another person's action opens social possibilities that ecological research has overlooked. The present synthesis therefore needs an explicit prospective contrast with later **actual explanation seeking** rather than novelty by juxtaposition.

Conscious experience, memory, and current interpretation

Nisbett and Wilson (1977) establish limits on verbal access to some processes influencing judgments; Johansson et al. (2005) show that people may explain experimentally altered choice outcomes. These results justify distinguishing a present feeling from a causal account of how it arose. They do not prove that the formation of most ordinary preferences was wholly unconscious. Conway and Pleydell-Pearce

(2000) and Johnson (2025) offer substantial accounts of memory, present purposes, subjective experience, and retrospective attribution. Barrett (2017) provides a prominent constructionist account of how learned concepts and bodily conditions contribute to emotional response.

Habits, momentum, and recurrence without a new processing stage

Habit research explains how repeated responding in stable contexts can make familiar actions likely without explicit reconsideration on every occasion (Wood, 2024). Psychological momentum describes how recently active thoughts, moods, task sets, and dispositions can influence what follows across seconds and minutes (Honey et al., 2023). These literatures give conventional routes by which an existing organization may affect later perception or action even when its origin is not deliberately rehearsed. They also prevent the mistake of treating every short-lived carry-forward as durable learning. A preference can remain stable through repeated encounters, a task set can persist briefly, and a newly explicit option can be used once without demonstrating that a general disposition has changed.

3. Analysis boundaries: opportunity, candidacy, valuation, and experience

Declare the environment, the person, the target, and the occasion

Consider a declared task at time t . Let $\mathbf{X}_t$ denote relevant external conditions, including the objects, people, displayed information, constraints, and available actions. Let $\mathbf{S}_t$ denote a model-relative description of the person's existing organization—skills, sensory conditions, expectations, learned practices, affective dispositions, goals, knowledge, and, where pertinent, preferences. $\mathbf{S}_t$ is not proposed as one observable neural variable; each included property must earn its place through a measurement, testable prediction, or explanatory requirement. A background preference is one possible aspect of $\mathbf{S}_t$, not the subject whose birth the experiment must explain. The studied event $\mathbf{E}_t$ is the actual encounter resulting from person–environment interaction, not an exogenous packet of information necessarily arriving unchanged to every observer.

An investigator can catalogue a set **O_t** of alternatives made materially or institutionally available within the experimental arrangement. This is a *researcher's operational opportunity set*, not an ontologically complete catalogue of every ecological affordance. Some alternatives may require skills or resources one participant lacks; when so, the experiment cannot claim they are equally usable merely because the same objects appeared on a table. Within a carefully characterized comparison, the researcher can assess several subsequent relationships to each alternative: was its relevant feature detected; did it become a candidate for the declared activity; how was it evaluated; and what was selected or realized?

The word **candidate** should not be conflated with a mental item necessarily represented in one discrete format. It is an operational claim about whether a possibility entered a participant's relevant consideration under the chosen probe. The theoretical literature differs over whether possibilities are represented, directly perceived, dynamically soliciting, or otherwise organized. FutureYou remains neutral on that disagreement where equivalent observations fit the alternatives. Its minimal architecture is about **which distinctions can be warranted**, not which architecture must exist inside the head.

A useful set of observation labels is **D** for evidence of perceptual detection or identification; **C** for candidate generation or current consideration; **V** for appraisal, valuation, felt fit, or appropriateness under specified questions; **A** for selected and realized action; **Q** for requested or inspected information; **I** for information actually delivered or demonstrably acquired; **J** for judgment about another person's use of an alternative; and **Y** for a later declared experiential, informational, or behavioral outcome. None is an obligatory serial stage. Several may be inseparable under particular methods, and 'felt' constructs require reporting or other validated assumptions not supplied by behavior alone. **R**, when recorded, is the person's account of why an option is or is not preferable; it is not an experimental record of how that disposition developed.

The basic dependence can be written conceptually as:

$$P(D_t, C_t, V_t, A_t, Q_t, J_t \mid S_t, X_t, E_t, M_t),$$

where M_t describes the measurement or probing regime. This expression is not a calibrated probability model and does not assert that the components are independent, simultaneously observed, or causally ordered as listed. It reminds investigators that a different prompt can create a different candidate set, that a change in surroundings can mimic an internal change, and that different dispositions may yield indistinguishable choices under a limited task.

A second, prospective question concerns the next encounter. The set of actually encountered information and opportunities at $t + 1$ may depend on which actions, explorations, avoidances, conversations, or judgments occurred at t . The scientific target is not a mandatory update operator between two states but a **conditional difference in later exposure and experience under identified earlier conditions**. For example, a person who never considers a book may never acquire information contained in it; a person who considers it and rejects it may produce the same immediate action yet remain differently responsive to a later book recommendation. A person who dismisses another person's keyboard preference may not ask about its functional advantages; one who recognizes it as legitimate may seek an explanation even without ever adopting the keyboard.

Availability, detection, candidacy, legitimacy, and realization

Availability is established at the level of a specified environment and task. **Detection** concerns evidence that the relevant object or feature was registered. **Candidacy** concerns whether it became an option for this purpose, under a defensible method. **Personal valuation** concerns what a participant reports or reveals about their own use of it. **Perceived legitimacy** concerns whether the alternative is regarded as reasonable or permissible, especially for somebody else. **Selection and realization** concern which action occurred, under what opportunity. The same endpoint—for example, selecting the small spoon—can arise through not detecting the other, failing to generate it, generating then rejecting it, or considering it worthwhile but selecting the small one because of a situational cost.

That is an underidentification result, not proof of five independent psychological machines. The distinctions should survive only when a different measurement or intervention makes them consequential.

If a task cannot distinguish detection from candidate generation, the correct local conclusion is a broader absence of demonstrated consideration. If changing a social-legitimacy judgment never modifies future information seeking, action, or interpretation under the declared horizon, the investigator should not preserve it as a necessary causal bridge.

The difference between **unconsidered** and **rejected** is central. A verbal rejection already implies some account of the alternative, whereas no spontaneous mention could result from low salience, memory retrieval failure, reporting limits, or the person's expectation that the experimenter wanted only a single answer. Controlled prompting can help determine whether the alternative was recognizable, but the act of prompting changes the encounter. An unprompted record must be collected before the investigator introduces the candidate. The post-prompt response addresses a second question: what happens **after the previously unmentioned option is made explicit?**

The social branch: judging another person's alternatives

One's own normality can be used in at least two ways. It may simply guide personal action: 'I use a small spoon.' Or it may implicitly generalize: 'People who choose large spoons are doing something strange.' That transition is not mandated by preference itself. Individuals may know that preferences differ; they may regard a personally unpleasant option as completely reasonable for somebody else. But when the translation occurs, it shapes the meaning assigned to another person's visible action.

For a social experiment, **J** could separately include estimated prevalence of the alternative preference, its perceived reasonableness, perceived competence or character of its holder, and willingness to ask about the holder's reasons. These are not one construct. A participant may think a preference rare without treating it as bad; may judge it costly without judging its holder irrational; may privately disapprove but remain willing to learn. Existing research on false consensus, attitude conflict, and naïve realism offers conventional explanations for relevant patterns (Ross et al., 1977; Minson & Dorison, 2022).

The account does not claim that having a preference caused prejudice or contempt. Perceived abnormality may arise from stereotypes, cultural norms, accuracy concerns, group identity, or task-specific evidence.

The research question is narrower: **when does a person’s existing practical or sensory organization affect their interpretation of another person’s options, and how does that interpretation influence subsequent information contact?** Measurement must separate ordinary disagreement from negative attribution and avoid inferring a generalized social bias from a trivial utensil preference alone.

Reporting, awareness, and inferential restraint

The core measurement principle is to label the result at its actual inferential level. If a participant freely lists three options, the study observed **three reported spontaneous candidates**, not the exhaustive contents of consciousness. If they subsequently select a fourth option after it is named, the study observed a **prompt-sensitive difference in the choice context**, not necessarily new learning. If they later use the fourth option without a prompt, the study may support an effect on later spontaneous selection, conditional on appropriate controls. These are scientifically different observations even when the everyday description of all three is simply ‘now they see it.’

Subjective experience can be a primary target without being a complete cause

The phenomenological character of an encounter matters to FutureYou. Someone can feel alienated by a device, satisfied by a familiar spoon, or puzzled by another person’s choice without changing overt action. Such reported experience can be a primary outcome. Yet the reported sensation does not directly reveal its historical origin, and the fact that it predicts subsequent behavior does not establish that it caused that behavior. Dispositions and context may jointly influence the report and the action.

A useful design separates a **current report** (‘this feels wrong’), an **origin account** (‘this is wrong because I grew up using the other one’), a **normative projection** (‘nobody should want this’), and a **future-facing decision** (‘I want to learn why someone uses it’). These are distinct measurements. A person can endorse the first and reject the second, recognize the third as unreasonable, and still decline the fourth. The outcomes need not combine into one psychological disposition.

Prompts change the experience under investigation

The study of unconsidered possibilities poses a measurement paradox: explicitly asking someone to consider alternatives makes those alternatives more likely to enter consideration. An experiment that always displays every option before asking for a choice cannot estimate the person's prior spontaneous candidate generation. A probe that asks, 'Did you think of using a book?' supplies a representation of the book as a possible answer. The design must treat that probe as an intervention, not a transparent window onto what preceded it.

One approach uses separate task conditions: spontaneous unprompted behavior, open-ended generated possibilities, prompted recognition, and transfer under later conditions without a repeated prompt. Reports can be delayed, counterbalanced, or randomized to assess reactivity. No-report and low-report conditions may reduce demand but cannot establish phenomenal absence; reports can be informative without being causally neutral (Tsuchiya et al., 2015). The appropriate goal is not a perfect reading of unreported consciousness but a set of contrasts that bound what became explicit and what later changed.

A judged preference is not necessarily an imposed norm

Judgments can also be justified by context. A participant might object to using a noisy keyboard in a shared quiet room, not to the other person's sensory preference as such. A learning method may be ineffective for a specified task, and the observer might correctly recognize that. The experiment should manipulate relevant situational information independently of mere preference mismatch. A finding that judgments track legitimate task constraints is not evidence of egocentric projection. The study must be capable of ruling in a simpler, more accurate explanation.

Conscious presence is neither required nor excluded

Existing sensory and cognitive organization may affect attention or option generation without a corresponding reportable decision. Deliberate comparison may likewise bring an alternative into view and change its status. Later recollection can be absent even if the person consciously noticed the original

event. Therefore present $\neq$ accessed; accessed $\neq$ used; used $\neq$ authoritative; considered $\neq$ selected; selected $\neq$ realized. These distinctions are not intended as a seven-layer ontology. They are safeguards against treating a single observation as evidence of all the others.

Where distinctions cannot be separated by available measurements, they should be merged or reported as observationally equivalent. The fact that human experience exceeds any one measurement is not a license to posit an invisible pathway whose presence is immune to failure. The manuscript remains concerned with lived experience while limiting causal attribution to effects that the specified design can warrant.

4. From personal encounter to interpersonal interpretation

Worked personal encounter: the larger spoon

Before the reach

Imagine a person who has consistently used smaller spoons. On a particular occasion there are two clean spoons beside a bowl. Both are adequate for eating. The researcher knows this because the participant has demonstrated the ability to use either, no relevant medical or physical limitation prevents the larger spoon's use, and the utensils have been selected to avoid obviously incompatible tasks. The researcher can also measure known differences in bowl shape, handle weight, tactile qualities, and mouth fit. Even with these precautions, a larger spoon is not sensorially identical to a smaller one. Its difference may be the very reason the participant favors the smaller implement.

Under an ordinary request—'please eat'—the participant reaches for the small spoon. This establishes selection under an opportunity. It does not show that the participant generated both alternatives, that only one was consciously present, or that a previous experience modified the participant during the current trial. The established preference belongs to the initial conditions of the encounter. The study begins at that point and asks what consequences follow.

A test of consideration that does not provide the answer first

A standard preference questionnaire—'Do you prefer the large or small spoon?'—makes both options explicit. It cannot establish whether the large spoon was part of the person's original practical option set.

A more relevant experiment first presents an open-ended task with multiple reasonable implements and records the sequence of spontaneous solutions before naming any specific alternative. One could ask participants to prepare a simple meal or accomplish a low-stakes task while documenting which implements they approach, request, or spontaneously list under a general planning instruction.

What happens when the investigator then explicitly introduces the alternative? The person might say, ‘Of course I could use that, but I don’t like it.’ That resembles **recognition followed by rejection**. Another might say, ‘I hadn’t thought of it; it would work fine,’ and subsequently try the alternative. A third could acknowledge the option but remain unable or unwilling to use it for a particular task. The prompt has made a previously unmentioned possibility part of the encounter, but the result is not automatically a preference change. The person’s original preference might remain untouched.

The alternative need not become preferred to become relevant

Suppose the person still likes the small spoon. The researcher offers a dish for which a larger spoon has some practical advantage but remains optional. Before earlier prompting, the participant might never have considered changing implements. After recognizing the alternative as usable, the same individual might select it for that particular situation while continuing to prefer the smaller spoon generally. This is a task-conditioned expansion of consideration, not necessarily a change in core taste or identity.

How the utensil becomes a social question

Now introduce another person who prefers the larger spoon. The first participant may regard this as perfectly ordinary, surprising but acceptable, or evidence of a poor choice. If the reaction is negative, the scientifically interesting question is not whether large spoons are objectively wrong. It is whether the first person’s own felt standard influences what they infer about the other person’s judgment, competence, taste, or reasonableness.

The observer may revise their judgment without changing their own choice. They may say, ‘That still feels wrong for me, but I see why someone else would choose it.’ This response separates **personal experienced fit** from **interpersonal legitimacy**. It is a potentially consequential change in the experienced meaning of another person’s action. The effect could influence whether the participant asks

further questions of that person later; an experiment must actually test such information seeking rather than assume it from a kinder rating.

The next encounter is the real endpoint

The utensil example becomes a FutureYou example only when the analysis moves beyond the current fork or spoon selection. The next encounter may be materially identical—a similar drawer tomorrow—but the person might now notice the alternative. It may involve a different task in which the alternative enters consideration. Or it may involve another person whose preference is interpreted differently, inviting or discouraging conversation. These are all ways that the earlier encounter and current organization can become consequential for subsequent human experience.

There is no required improvement. The person may continue as before. The prompt may briefly interrupt a routine and leave no longer-term difference. The individual may regard the other person's preference as more intelligible yet avoid using the unfamiliar utensil personally. The social judgment might become more hostile rather than more understanding if new information conflicts with expectations. The account seeks to distinguish these possible trajectories; it does not define every outcome as progress.

Most importantly, the next encounter may be **an encounter the person never has**. If a learning option never enters consideration, the information it would have provided may remain unencountered. If another person's preference is dismissed, the explanation they might offer may never be heard. Such absences can be hard to measure because no observable endpoint directly displays the unrealized path. Experiments need controlled opportunity sets, recorded offers, randomized invitations, and carefully bounded counterfactual contrasts. The unseen alternative cannot be inferred simply by noting that a different future was imaginable to the investigator.

Worked interpersonal encounter: another person's unfamiliar preference

From private fit to the interpretation of another person

A second worked case begins with a keyboard user who likes tactile switches. A coworker prefers quiet linear switches. Both can type competently. The first user may experience the coworker's keyboard as

unpleasant, and may go further by treating the coworker's selection as evidence of poor judgment. The first reaction concerns the observer's anticipated or current sensory experience; the second concerns an inference about another person. The latter does not follow logically from the former. A device can be wrong *for my purposes* without being wrong *for another person's purposes*. Nevertheless, ordinary judgments sometimes cross that boundary.

A participant who has personally never considered an alternative can nonetheless be confronted with it through another person's action. In this sense the other person reveals a possibility that the observer did not generate spontaneously. What happens next is variable. The observer may dismiss it, request an explanation, imitate it, avoid the person, or integrate it into a broader view of what human preferences can reasonably be. The important point is that **another person's preference can function as a new informational encounter**, even when neither person changes their preferred object.

Prevalence judgments are different from legitimacy judgments

An individual might say, 'Almost everyone prefers clicky keyboards,' based partly on their own preference or the people they routinely encounter. That is a prevalence estimate. Another statement —'Nobody sensible would want linear switches'—is a judgment about legitimacy or competence. A third —'I don't understand the appeal'—is an account of the observer's own lack of experiential access. These statements can co-occur, but they are not the same construct. Treating them as one 'judging others' score would prevent meaningful causal interpretation.

What the observer learns and what they choose not to learn

The social feedback question arises when the observer is offered an opportunity to find out more. They could ask the coworker why the quiet switch is preferred, hear about a shared office, learn about noise sensitivity, or discover differences in task requirements. They could also refrain, perhaps because they feel no uncertainty or because hearing an alternative explanation seems unnecessary. These possible paths matter because subsequent information environments are partly created by social interaction.

A study should independently observe the opportunity to request information, the actual request, whether an explanation was delivered, whether the participant attended to or understood it, and any later change in

evaluation. Merely reporting increased tolerance does not show that the participant will seek other people's reasons. Likewise, voluntarily hearing an explanation does not establish that the participant uses it. The relation from **judgment to contact with information** may be absent, reversed, or mediated by other factors such as curiosity, impression management, and perceived social reward.

The discriminating personal-to-interpersonal bridge

The relationship between personal consideration and social interpretation must do more scientific work than place two literatures in neighboring sections. One bounded **bridge hypothesis** is this: *holding the observer's existing preference, the other person's displayed choice, and the information offered afterward as constant, an earlier randomized cue that makes an alternative relevant to the observer's own task may change how the observer evaluates that same alternative when another person selects it, and whether the observer subsequently seeks that person's explanation.* This does not mean that personal candidacy causes social legitimacy. It asserts a testable interaction between two experimentally controlled **encounters**, with any mediator left unidentified unless separately manipulated.

Consider a typist who strongly prefers tactile switches, but who has not spontaneously mentioned silent switches as a plausible tool in a task. In one condition, the participant receives a neutral, equally specific cue to a silent switch as a usable alternative for a quiet workspace; in another, the participant receives a matched cue about a different usable option. Later, a coworker is depicted choosing either the previously cued or the other switch, under a task in which both work. The participant may continue preferring tactile feedback, but their rating of the coworker's reasonableness and their voluntary request for the coworker's explanation may depend on the conjunction of the earlier cue and the other's displayed choice. The decisive contrast is an **interaction**, not the main effect of liking, exposure, or disagreement alone.

A personal-choice task can show which option a person uses, and a social-rating task can show how that person evaluates someone else's choice. Neither establishes whether an earlier cue to a personally usable alternative affects a later voluntary request to hear the other person's reasons, depending on what that person chose. The crossed comparison tests that link without identifying a subjective mediator.

5. Further human domains: media, tools, preferences, and learning

Physical book versus e-reader: a missing informational pathway

A controlled study could create a problem whose solution is available through several known methods: printed instructions, an e-reader, a brief demonstration, or hands-on experimentation. Participants first generate their own approaches without the experimenter naming each method. Their later response to an explicitly displayed choice panel can be compared with the spontaneous list, keeping in mind that the panel transforms the choice situation. Reading experience, device literacy, sensory accommodation, and genuine cost differences are measured. The study then tracks which method is selected and what information is actually encountered. An important possible result is that individuals whose preferred route is absent spontaneously can nevertheless recognize and competently use another route after prompting. The published comparisons of comprehension across print and screens (Delgado et al., 2018; Clinton, 2019) concern different questions from spontaneously considering a format as an informational route. They are useful controls: a measured difference in what participants later understand might arise from presentation characteristics or task demands, not only from the person's choice to seek one source. The investigation should distinguish *not seeking* a resource from *failing to understand* an encountered resource and from *having a different reading experience* under equally understood text.

Keyboard preferences: different physical feedback and different interpretations of normality

The keyboard comparison distinguishes immediate sensory response from the absence of a generated option and from social inference. Direct physical fit may explain the personal preference; the respondent's estimate of what other people ought to enjoy requires additional social evidence. Experiments can manipulate switch feel and sound separately if equipment permits, keep typing tasks matched, and observe information-seeking opportunities after participants learn that another experienced typist favors a different switch. A changed social appraisal need not be accompanied by changed typing accuracy, preference, or purchase behavior.

Coke versus Pepsi: familiar evaluation, missing comparison, and attributed taste

Brand-cue research supports a distinction between the beverage and contextual information shaping its reported evaluation (McClure et al., 2004). In the present paper, the key question comes earlier: when an established Coke drinker approaches a choice situation, does Pepsi emerge as a relevant candidate? That cannot be inferred merely because both appear in the refrigerator or because the participant chooses Coke when both labels are shown on a questionnaire.

An experiment can first observe free sampling or spontaneous beverage requests under a constrained set of feasible alternatives, then present a randomized opportunity to taste a previously unrequested option under blind and labeled conditions. The design must control thirst, temperature, sensory differences, caffeine, familiarity, and demand. The participant may remain a Coke drinker yet learn that the alternative is acceptable or understand why someone else prefers it. The later effect may be willingness to consider an alternative in a different context, not a reversal in favorite brand. Lifetime brand exposure cannot be randomized retroactively; claims about how the original preference formed remain outside the primary research target.

Classroom versus direct experience: an unavailable route to information

For a reader, experimenter, or hands-on learner, the strongest design distinguishes whether the alternative learning route is known, considered, selected, encountered, understood, and used. A participant might accurately explain that a book contains relevant knowledge but not spontaneously generate it as a next action. After a neutral demonstration of the book's relevance, the participant may consult it while still preferring active learning overall. Alternatively, they may reject it because the task really requires physical feedback not supplied by a text. Those alternatives need not be treated as irrational or deficient. Deslauriers et al. (2019) and Freeman et al. (2014) establish important facts about learning and subjective assessment in specified educational settings. They do not establish that every preference for active participation causes the omission of books, or vice versa. The additional FutureYou question is whether **experienced informational possibility** changes which encounters are voluntarily sought next, and

whether making another method legible expands future learning opportunities without requiring the person to renounce a prior preference.

The generalization is a question structure, not a common sensory mechanism

The same analysis may reveal different failure points. The preferred utensil may be selected without competing candidacy; the e-reader may be considered yet avoided; the beverage may be selected because of a current label; the instructional route may never be generated; the coworker's preference may be recognized but deemed unreasonable. The scientific benefit is not that every phenomenon produces identical data. It is that each can be investigated without equating objective availability with consideration, preference with social authority, or recognition with later use.

6. Causal questions across encounters

What is manipulated and what is merely observed

For a particular trial or encounter, researchers should distinguish **B**, measured baseline organization; **X**, task and external conditions; **Z**, an assigned intervention making an alternative salient or altering opportunity; **C**, observed spontaneous candidate generation or later recognition; **J**, judgment about another person's alternative; **Q**, selection or request for subsequent information; **I**, information actually supplied and understood as separately assessed; and **Y**, a prespecified later outcome. These symbols are optional bookkeeping devices. They are not mandatory organismic subprocesses.

For example, a randomized prompt **Z** naming a book as a resource may change **C** at the next learning problem. That establishes a bounded effect of the prompt on observed option generation. If a later manipulated information opportunity affects **Y**, a second causal link may be established. Neither result alone proves that felt preference **V** mediated the prompt effect. A participant's current organization may influence what the prompt means, but preference is generally observed rather than randomized; any preference-specific causal attribution requires additional assumptions or manipulations.

The next encounter may differ because an option was omitted

The prospective significance of an unconsidered option lies in future opportunity. Imagine an information environment offering a book, a demonstration, and direct experimentation. A participant might always choose the demonstration. If the book never enters candidacy, the later information distribution may be narrower than if it had. But the scientist cannot assume that a missed book would have improved understanding. The alternative information might be redundant, misleading, or unsuitable for the task. The legitimate counterfactual question is whether intervention on the availability or salience of that route changes what is later encountered and, if so, what measurable consequence follows.

Two designs ask different questions. In a **fixed-information condition**, all participants receive specified later material; the researcher estimates how prior organization or prompt assignment relates to the experience of that common material. In a **self-directed condition**, participants have an experimentally defined choice of later resources. Here a prompt can affect which material is selected, and that material can influence subsequent interpretation. Comparing these settings may reveal whether a history effect operates primarily through exposure opportunity or through response to common information. But self-selection also changes agency, effort, and engagement, so a free-versus-yoked comparison is not a pure manipulation of information content (Markant & Gureckis, 2014).

Historical influence and present-state sufficiency

The temporal account also needs a disciplined role for history. Let H represent prior encounters, S the current measured person-related state, X future conditions, and Y a declared future outcome. A predictive sufficiency test can ask whether

$$P(Y \mid S, X, H) = P(Y \mid S, X)$$

within the measured domain. If a sufficiently specified current state makes history predictively redundant, there is no need to retain a separate historical predictor for that task. This does not demonstrate that previous experience had no causal role in producing S . Conditioning on a post-exposure state can block a genuine total effect; selection effects can even introduce bias. The **total effect of assigned history** and

the **incremental predictive value of past history after current measurement** are different estimands and should not be conflated.

Later information is not equivalent to later understanding

An option becoming explicit does not prove it was selected. Selection of a book does not prove that the book was opened. Opening a passage does not prove attention, understanding, memory, or later use. Similarly, hearing someone else's reason does not prove the reason becomes authoritative for interpreting their behavior. The researcher should record offered, selected, delivered, attended, understood, and subsequently used information where the specific inference requires those distinctions.

The minimal causal contrast and its inferential ceiling

The smallest study connecting personal and social encounters randomizes **Z**, whether a specific previously unmentioned yet independently usable alternative is foregrounded in an initial personal task, and independently randomizes **M**, whether a later social target selects that alternative or a matched, equally feasible comparison. Prior personal preference **B** is measured before either assignment and used for stratification or effect heterogeneity, not interpreted as an experimentally manipulated cause. Let **L** be the observed later legitimacy or reasonableness report; let **Q** be an opportunity-controlled voluntary request for an explanation. The primary bridge estimand is the intention-to-treat interaction:

$$\Delta_{ZM}^Q = \{E[Q \mid Z=1, M=1] - E[Q \mid Z=0, M=1]\} - \{E[Q \mid Z=1, M=0] - E[Q \mid Z=0, M=0]\}.$$

The analogous contrast for **L** is secondary. All four cells must use matched tasks, comparable information costs, and counterbalanced alternative identities. Because **Z** and **M** are assigned, their interaction estimates a causal **joint assignment effect** under the design's standard assumptions. It does not establish that prior option generation, changed phenomenal awareness, or **L** mediated any effect on **Q**. The strongest evidence for the complete prospective route would additionally require showing that the requested information was delivered and that independently randomized information content affected a

later interpretation. Those are separate estimands. A study may legitimately stop at the experimentally identified interaction.

The interaction can be zero although the cue and other's action each exert meaningful separate effects. It can be nonzero because of familiar priming or updated task knowledge rather than experienced fit. A negative result therefore contracts the proposed personal–social bridge, not all of affordance theory, social inference, or the reality of personal preferences. This measurement does not establish that the observer previously failed to experience the alternative phenomenally. An observation of **unmentioned** or **not behaviorally generated** remains the defensible baseline category.

7. Proposed experimental program and local failure conditions

Program logic and the first decisive contrast

The sequence should begin with a pilot using ordinary, low-risk informational tasks rather than highly intimate choices. Participants could be asked to solve a novel practical problem using resources that are independently confirmed to be within their capacities: a written guide, a demonstration, direct manipulation, and access to an informed helper. To avoid reducing the study to the narrow attractiveness of specific resources, materials and task demands should be counterbalanced across conditions. The investigator should ensure that an alternative was actually obtainable and usable, not merely listed in a catalogue from which some participants were effectively excluded.

At baseline, gather enough information to characterize relevant past familiarity, task knowledge, sensory restrictions, and preferred methods, without forcing participants to declare every possible alternative. The key baseline outcome is what they spontaneously do or generate under an open-ended instruction. A separate group may be asked to list possible approaches, because listing itself encourages generation and may alter subsequent behavior. Researchers should predefine a coding scheme for materially distinct candidates and use independent coders who are blind to the relevant condition.

Study A: spontaneous candidacy, prompted recognition, and later transfer

Initial task. Participants encounter a problem with several controlled resource types and no displayed forced-choice menu. The task is sufficiently open to allow more than one defensible approach but bounded enough that the full relevant resource inventory can be checked. Record first actions, open-ended solutions where elicited, time allocation, resource visits, and what information was actually received. The central measured outcome is the spontaneous consideration or use of each available resource, not merely the terminal correctness of the answer.

Independent opportunity verification. After the first task, measure whether participants recognize each resource, understand its function, and could have used it under the original conditions. This is a post-encounter recognition measure; it cannot be used as if it transparently characterized what the participant had considered beforehand. For some participants, recognition probes should be delayed until after the primary transfer outcome, so the effect of the verification procedure itself can be estimated.

Prompt intervention. Randomly assign participants to one of several subsequent conditions. A *relevance prompt* explains that an unmentioned resource can be useful without directing them to select it. An *attention-control prompt* draws attention to a similarly prominent but less relevant feature. An *explicit-choice condition* displays all feasible approaches. A *neutral continuation* offers another task without a new suggestion. These conditions differ in more than salience: they may affect demand, perceived authority, and problem representation. The design should measure those effects rather than pretending the prompt isolates one pure cognitive process.

Transfer task. The principal later assessment introduces a different but related problem in which the previously unmentioned resource can be useful. The resource is available but not explicitly recommended again. Predefine whether the primary outcome is spontaneous candidate generation, actual resource selection, or a combination; do not choose after seeing the strongest result. Also assess whether global preference for the participant's usual learning route has changed. The key possible pattern is **new consideration or use with an unchanged preference**.

Primary estimand. Under randomized assignment, estimate the difference in later spontaneous candidacy or use between the relevance prompt and a suitable control among participants meeting the prespecified initial nonmention criterion. Selecting participants based on pre-randomization spontaneous behavior is admissible for this targeted estimand, though it changes the target population; selection after treatment would risk bias. The initial classification should not be interpreted as proof that the alternative was phenomenally absent.

Matched intervention content and temporal protection. Eligibility as a participant who has not *demonstrated* a named alternative must be determined before randomization, not by conditioning on post-cue behavior. If a delayed screening session is used to verify practical ability, it must be scheduled and analyzed as an encounter that could have increased salience; a separate validation cohort can instead establish that the resources are generally accessible without priming the confirmatory group. Preassign a focal alternative among feasible resources; do not choose the most surprising omitted item after seeing each person's response. Pretest target alternatives for matched task relevance, familiarity, reading difficulty, and practical effort.

Use a **specific option-cue condition** naming focal resource A; an **equally specific alternative-cue condition** naming resource B, pretested for comparable relevance and informativeness; a **generic attention cue** matching length and claimed source while identifying no specific alternative; and, where sample size permits, a **task-relevance information condition** that explicitly teaches a relevant property of A. Across conditions, keep directive wording, display duration, perceived authority, and expected task cost as close as possible. Record an independent manipulation check after the primary unprompted transfer to avoid contaminating that endpoint. The A-versus-B contrast tests **option-specific foregrounding under matched cue structure**; it is not a pure isolation of consciousness or retrieval. The A-versus-task-knowledge comparison tests how an explicit useful fact contributes beyond mere naming, but learning and salience cannot always be factored perfectly. A no-probe subgroup tests measurement reactivity. Immediate recognition can be measured in a distinct group to avoid creating the very later behavior being studied.

Primary and secondary endpoints. Predefine a specific related problem offered after a meaningful interval, ideally with an interference task and—if feasible—a separate-day follow-up. The primary endpoint is whether A is **spontaneously named or used** in that later unprompted task; selection and verified information acquisition are secondary. A preregistered ITT contrast compares assigned A cue with assigned B cue. Preference stability is evaluated separately and not imposed as a post-randomization eligibility rule. Demands, recall, factual knowledge of the resource, and perceived experimenter recommendation are measured after the primary endpoint and used as explanatory or sensitivity checks, not as evidence that the cue caused a unique internal route.

What the comparison cannot settle. Even well matched A/B prompts can differ in latent attractiveness or novelty. A participant may have fleetingly considered A during baseline but not reported it. A positive delayed result can be retrieval, attention, task-rule transfer, explicit learning, or compliance with perceived experimenter aims. Report the randomized effect on later *demonstrated* consideration, not an inferred transition from phenomenal nonexistence to conscious possibility. If the effect disappears with genuinely matched cue relevance, a generalized prompt-specific advantage does not survive.

Failure and interpretation. An effect limited to immediate prompted recognition but absent in delayed transfer does not support a further carry-forward claim at that lag. A positive transfer result may reflect memory for a suggestion, an updated task rule, reduced uncertainty, or a changed habit of sampling; it should not be assigned to an unmeasured conscious realization. If all baseline alternatives are spontaneously generated or the relevant resource offers no feasible advantage, the design does not test omission as intended. The study should report that limitation rather than forcing the result into a theory of missing possibilities.

Study B: can a newly considered information route change what is learned next?

Let Z denote the earlier relevance-prompt assignment, Q the later selected resource, I the content supplied, and Y a measured subsequent outcome such as conceptual understanding, an ability to identify useful evidence, or reported confidence under a specified problem. A randomized contrast of Z can

estimate the total effect on Q or Y under the experimental regime. Randomized manipulation of I can estimate its effect on Y. A comparison of voluntary selection with externally assigned information can estimate the effect of the *assignment regime*, which may include agency and attention differences. It cannot by itself identify a natural mediated effect $Z \rightarrow Q \rightarrow I \rightarrow Y$.

The value of the joint design is that a participant who never voluntarily chooses a resource may not receive the same informational content as someone who does. Under a later fixed-information condition, both participants receive matched content, allowing a separate assessment of whether they use it differently. If a history-related disparity in Y appears during voluntary selection and contracts under fixed equivalent delivery, informational access is a plausible contributing explanation. But motivation, engagement, and selection-related effects may also change between regimes, so a strong causal conclusion requires matched conditions, factorial controls, or bounded sensitivity analysis (Imai et al., 2010).

A well-supported result could identify two links without establishing a complete psychological pathway: the earlier prompt changes later information choice, and independently delivered information changes a further outcome. The manuscript should present those links as jointly relevant but not claim that the original personal preference or conscious awareness mediated them. A complete mediated claim would require additional design or assumptions. This is a constraint on interpretation, not a requirement to invent a general integration process.

Study C: personal preference, another person's choice, and social judgment

The interpersonal experiment begins with an existing, independently assessed preference in a low-stakes domain. Mechanical keyboard feedback, writing instruments, or harmless sensory arrangements are preferable first targets to ideologically or morally charged issues. The participant evaluates a target person who either shares or differs from the participant's preference. The target's demonstrated performance and opportunity are held comparable when those facts bear on the judgment.

Social information manipulation. Randomize whether the observer receives (i) no additional explanation, (ii) a task-relevant and credible explanation of the target's selection, (iii) a comparable amount of neutral information, or (iv) information indicating that the choice was situationally constrained rather than freely preferred. The distinction between choice and constraint is important: observers may attribute character differently depending on whether they believe the target could have acted otherwise. Information about the target's reasons must not be constructed to present a preferred alternative as morally superior by definition.

Measurements. Predefine separate outcomes for perceived normality, perceived legitimacy, inferred competence, affective reaction, and interest in further explanation. A voluntary later opportunity might permit the participant to request the target's account, examine evidence about the device, or choose unrelated information at similar effort. The question is whether personal preference mismatch affects either social interpretation or subsequent informational contact under matched conditions. Measures should allow a participant to disagree without being forced to describe the other as defective.

Prospective outcome. A second encounter can present another person's different preference or an unrelated new option, after the initial social explanation. Test whether participants now generate more than one plausible reason for a different choice or voluntarily inspect more explanatory information. A change in perceived legitimacy without a change in the participant's own preferred keyboard would support separation of personal fit from social inference. A change in later information seeking would identify an additional consequence only under appropriate intervention and controls.

Failure conditions. If own preference has no reliable relationship to social judgments, do not assert a personal-to-social projection in this domain. If contextual explanations shift public ratings but not private, anonymous, or delayed outcomes, the effect may be demand-limited. If informational contact changes because of reduced search cost rather than judgment, do not attribute it to a newly legitimized alternative. High-stakes extensions require separate ethical and causal justification.

Crossed personal-cue × other-person-choice test: the decisive bridge

Participants and preparation. Begin with participants who have an independently measured, stable personal preference among low-stakes alternatives (e.g., switch feedback or feasible learning resources). On an unprompted personal task, record behavioral resource visits and, in a separate measurement subgroup, freely generated candidates. Use no claim that unmentioned options were absent from private consciousness. A focal alternative and a matched comparison are assigned **before** treatment based on external usability pretests. If initial nonmention is an eligibility criterion, ascertain it before randomization; participants who do spontaneously name the focal option are retained in a prespecified separate stratum or excluded under a declared target-population rule, never selected after treatment.

Two independent assignments. Randomize **Z** to an equally credible, equally detailed cue foregrounding focal alternative A versus matched alternative B during a personal task. Where possible the option-description is factual, nonnormative and equally relevant; perceived authority and instruction strength are balanced. Independently randomize **M** to a new target person choosing A or B. Counterbalance which physical switch, learning route, or everyday object is coded A, and hold demonstrated target competence, opportunity, and stakes constant. A further balanced explanatory-information factor **R** may later supply a credible task-specific reason, an equally lengthy neutral fact, or no additional information. The **R** manipulation occurs **after** the first social judgment, with the timing fixed in advance, so its later effect is not confused with the Z-by-M comparison.

Ordering. Day/session one: baseline personal fit, capability, and unprompted task; randomize **Z**; deliver brief standardized personal-task cue. At a later session or suitably delayed transfer: assess an unprompted personal candidate response before mentioning the social target; then randomize **M** and present the target's choice; measure perceived prevalence, personal pleasantness, task-specific reasonableness, interpersonal legitimacy, and competence attribution under distinct questions. Offer each participant the same private, optional opportunity to inspect a short explanation of the target's choice at the same effort/cost; log request, actual opening, and comprehension where claiming information acquisition. Only

then deliver randomized R where included and assess a fresh later scenario without repeating an identical explicit probe. Reported origin narratives are optional and never substitutes for assignment logs.

Because social ratings precede the optional private explanation request Q, the $Z \times M$ interaction on Q is identified under this ratings-before-request measurement regime. The ratings may affect attention, curiosity, perceived social expectations, or the anticipated value of hearing an explanation. The result does not establish an equivalent effect on an unprobed request or mediation by any of those ratings.

Primary estimand. The prespecified ITT $Z \times M$ **interaction on actual voluntary explanation request Q** (defined mathematically in the causal-contrast section) measures whether the personal-task cue's subsequent effect depends on the other's selected alternative. A minimum effect of scientific interest must be preregistered from pilot data; precision and equivalence bounds matter more than fishing for significance. The personal-option transfer and social-legitimacy interaction are secondary; a three-way interaction with R is exploratory unless independently powered. A nonzero effect supports a bounded **cross-encounter experimental interaction**, not mediation by felt rightness, or a specific new social mechanism.

Competitors, discriminating predictions, and failure. Under a context-only account, equivalent external social evidence at test should explain Q regardless of Z history. Under a generic cue/demand account, all equally specific cues should elevate information requests similarly without A/B alignment; under a support-theory or social-projection account, cue effects may be selective to less-preferred or newly unpacked alternatives and can produce exactly the target interaction without any new construct (Brenner & Bilgin, 2011). A task-information account predicts stronger effects only when Z conveyed diagnostic facts, requiring a matched salience-only condition. An affordance or perspective-taking account can predict sensitivity to the target's actual capability or situation (van Dijk & Rietveld, 2017; Creem-Regehr et al., 2013). With no reliable Z-by-M interaction on Q, or effects eliminated by matched information and generic cue controls, the **prospective personal-social bridge is unsupported** for that domain and should not be asserted from coincident changes in ratings. If the interaction appears but the

known rivals reproduce it, give those rivals explanatory credit; the study has still applied a joined measurement question but has not discovered an exclusive process.

Secondary information intervention. Participants who request an explanation should not be contrasted causally with nonrequesters without accounting for selection. A separate randomized content-delivery group can estimate the effect of receiving an explanation on a later belief or reported felt significance independent of the participant's request. The effect of Z on Q and the effect of randomized delivery on a later outcome are separately identified; their coexistence does not establish mediation from Z through Q. Missing reports of an unchosen source represent **unrealized controlled opportunities**, not directly observed counterfactual experiences.

Study D: cross-domain transport without a universal metric

The first three studies establish local causal contrasts in informational and social situations. A cross-domain replication asks whether the **distinction among available, spontaneously considered, explicitly recognized, socially evaluated, and subsequently pursued alternatives** provides useful inferential organization across at least two materially different domains. The transfer test should not compare a spoon-liking score numerically with classroom confidence or keyboard comfort. It should compare the *structure of the causal contrasts*.

An exact cross-domain effect size is neither promised nor necessary for a successful synthesis. A sensory preference may affect one's own action but not social judgment. An instructional preference may influence resource choice but not current subjective comfort. Another domain may show a purely contextual effect with no durable person-carried consequence. Those differences can identify where the general explanatory question is useful and where particular links fail.

Measurement validation and design discipline

All studies require advance specification of the target population, task opportunities, option-coding reliability, reporting regime, primary outcomes, follow-up horizon, smallest effects of scientific interest,

missing-data handling, and sample-size assumptions. A numerical power claim would be premature without pilot estimates. Multiple endpoints should be handled through planned hierarchical tests or appropriate multiplicity methods. The first experiment should have one clear primary contrast, not a flexible list of whichever outcome eventually becomes significant. The most discriminating follow-up is the existing crossed personal-cue $\times$ social-target protocol, with the interaction on voluntary private explanation requests specified before examining outcome data.

Spontaneous generation is especially vulnerable to construct validity problems. A missing candidate might reflect a verbal-demand artifact, slow retrieval, indifference, a task instruction misunderstood, or a genuine failure to recruit the possibility into consideration. Behavioral, open-ended, and post-prompt probes can triangulate the result but may also affect each other. Blinded coding, counterbalanced presentation, pretested task relevance, and delayed transfer are necessary for a claim that changes in consideration have future consequences.

Later experiential outcome must also be specified narrowly. If the person says a new option now seems reasonable, that is a report of evaluation. If they request an explanation, that is an information-seeking action. If they hear an explanation, exposure is documented. If they interpret the next event differently, that later interpretation can be measured. None alone is a complete measure of lived consciousness or of all future experience. The study earns its causal claim by testing the specific link it names.

Predicted contrasts, rivals, and failure conditions

Personal fit and attributed legitimacy can dissociate. A participant may continue disliking an option personally while coming to regard another person's use of it as intelligible or legitimate, or may personally tolerate an option while still judging it socially inappropriate in a defined context. A valid test measures the two constructs separately rather than equating disagreement with condemnation.

Social interpretation may condition later informational contact. Under some circumstances, another person's contrasting preference and its explanation will alter an observer's subsequent willingness to inspect that person's reasons or related information. An experimentally identified effect of supplied

explanation on later request need not be mediated by a change in perceived legitimacy unless that pathway is separately tested.

Current organization and context remain adequate rival explanations. If experimental differences in subsequent opportunities disappear when relevant sensory affordances, task demands, or information access are equated, a claim of independent person-carried modification contracts. If the measured current state sufficiently predicts the later target, an extra historical variable need not be retained for that query, even if history contributed causally to the present state.

The principal **scientific kill condition** for a standalone FutureYou contribution is not failure to show that people have preferences. It is that no nonredundant inferential or experimental function remains after comparison with complete ecological-affordance, option-generation, active-information-sampling, and social-cognition frameworks. If the strongest preceding accounts already supply the entire question, relevant distinctions, and adequate tests at the same level, the independent theoretical contribution is SUBSUMED. A bounded empirical null instead contracts only the link tested, while preserving well-established relationships elsewhere.

Cross-encounter personal/social interaction remains testable, not guaranteed. Independently manipulating which feasible alternative is foregrounded in a personal task and which matched alternative another person later selects should permit an intention-to-treat test of their interaction on voluntary, equally costly requests for the other's explanation. A nonzero interaction is compatible with ordinary priming, support-theory unpacking, and socially situated affordances. A credible null within a preregistered equivalence interval contracts this specific bridge even if option generation and social inference each separately occur. No mediation through reported feeling or social legitimacy is inferred from the interaction alone.

8. Same-level prior art, model competition, and limits

The strongest full-function predecessors

A scientifically fair comparison must evaluate what the established accounts already do **together**, not merely whether they mention one concept used here. The following comparison separates their actual functional scopes from the specific prospective question used by *FutureYou*.

Dewey (1896, 1938) treats experience and action as continuous across encounters, while Barsalou (2008, 2009) explains situated conceptual processing in grounded terms. Both already connect past experience to what can become relevant in later action. *FutureYou* uses that established continuity to distinguish personally generated possibilities, judgments about another person, and subsequent information requests; it does not introduce a new principle of experiential continuity.

Rietveld and Kiverstein (2014), van Dijk and Rietveld (2017), and Kiverstein and Rietveld (2021) explain lived fields of affordances, skilled engagement, and social coordination within shared practices. Their frameworks already address much of the person-relative, socially meaningful possibility at issue here. *FutureYou* instead specifies a narrower test: whether an earlier personal-option cue interacts with another person's later displayed choice in predicting a voluntary request for explanation, without claiming a different affordance mechanism.

Hauser and Wernerfelt (1990) model the costs of considering alternatives, and Aguiar et al. (2023) use menu and attention-frame variation to examine limited consideration. These approaches already distinguish what is available, considered, and selected, including the underidentification of consideration from choices alone. *FutureYou* carries those established measurement constraints into later social interpretation and explanation requests, not the principal reported outcomes of those studies; an extended consideration model could also explain the results.

Kalis et al. (2013) analyze how options are generated rather than merely selected from a supplied menu; Kaiser et al. (2013) compare generated and externally provided options using behavioral and neural tasks. The spontaneous-versus-prompted distinction is therefore established. *FutureYou* does not propose a new

option-generation faculty; it asks whether assigning an earlier personal cue has consequences for a separately observed other-person choice and later information request.

Pirolli and Card (1999), Gureckis and Markant (2012), Markant and Gureckis (2014), and Gottlieb and Oudeyer (2018) explain information foraging, self-directed learning, and active versus passive sampling. They already show why a person's selection of information matters to subsequent exposure and learning. FutureYou connects that established function to earlier personal option consideration and the decision whether to request another person's explanation; information seeking itself is not newly discovered. Ross et al. (1977) document self-referential prevalence judgments, and Brenner and Bilgin (2011) experimentally link own preferences and option-description salience to predictions of others' preferences through support theory. The connection from personal alternatives to social estimates is thus already substantial. FutureYou adds a prospective behavioral request for an explanation after independent manipulation of a previous personal cue and the displayed social option, while preserving support theory as a potential complete account.

Creem-Regehr et al. (2013) examine perspective-taking about another person's action possibilities, and Minson and Dorison (2022) review why contrary social information can be aversive. Both address important parts of how self-other judgments condition social informational exposure. The narrower FutureYou test joins an assigned earlier personal candidate cue, the other person's displayed choice, and a later private explanation request; differences in real opportunities or anticipated value remain viable explanations.

As noted in §2, Liquin and Lombrozo (2020) also establish that anticipated future learning and usefulness help explain explanation-seeking curiosity. The voluntary request Q is therefore not a newly discovered motivation. Dorison et al. (2019) likewise establish social-expectation effects on later information consumption. The prospective crossed assignment is a bounded application that these established accounts may explain.

What the synthesis contributes, and what it cannot claim

The defensible present contribution is **a joined research question and a fully specified identification protocol**. The protocol asks whether a controlled cue in a personal task changes an individual's later interpretation of another person's matched, alternative choice and changes whether the individual actually seeks the person's explanation, while remaining careful about stable personal preference, offered versus received information, and prompting as an encounter. It supplies an interaction contrast, falsifying local null, and explicit rival paths. The integration matters as a methodological discipline because a study that ends with the observer's initial choice cannot test a later socially generated informational opportunity, while a stand-alone social-rating study with no assigned previous personal cue cannot identify a carry-forward assignment effect. That constitutes an *application-level inferential function*, not proof of a new general psychological process.

The strongest opposing interpretation is that a comprehensive model combining consideration, support theory, learned salience, and socially situated affordances **already supplies every required prediction and contrast**. If so, the correct scientific status is *PRECEDENTED integration* or **SUBSUMED as an independent theory**, while the paper can still serve as a constrained interdisciplinary synthesis or experimental design guide. A cross-domain synthesis does not become valueless simply because competent existing theory can interpret the result; neither does it become original merely by renaming the complete model. The actual value claim must remain at the level of the inferential composition, its usable controls, and the human-experience problem it makes accessible.

A comparison that can give established theories the win

The proposed first empirical test uses a common prospective protocol to evaluate preregistered predictions from a full conventional explanatory model and other specified rivals. The conventional model may incorporate consideration-set processes, baseline preferences, cue-specific familiarity, target-choice information, support-theoretic preference projection, social affordances, and propensity to request information. The joined protocol records the same participants' unprompted personal candidates, a

randomized option cue, independently randomized displayed social alternatives, legitimacy reports, voluntary private explanation requests, and later actual content reception. Compare rival predictions against prespecified $Z \times M$ assignment interactions on Q, later information-contact measures, and held-out transfer outcomes, while limiting causal conclusions to contrasts licensed by the interventions. The protocol is an experimental measurement and identification design, not a competing psychological model. A conventional account may predict every tested effect and deserves explanatory credit if it does. Where the joined measurements permit an inference that disconnected personal-choice or social-rating endpoints cannot, claim that bounded inferential contribution, not theoretical superiority.

No existing source located in this targeted review was verified to have performed **exactly this complete crossed personal-task-cue $\times$ other-person-choice $\times$ subsequent private explanation-request protocol** across the specified human-experience examples. That limited search result is not evidence that none exists. Novelty of the *whole paper* remains **OPEN**; separate components and several substantial combinations are **PRECEDENTED**. Because the article is positioned as a **theoretically grounded inferential synthesis**, rather than a new neural theory or a claim of independent empirical discovery, that uncertainty does not demand speculative additional variables.

Conditions for a genuine contribution and for contraction

The paper does nontrivial work only when it shows why the joined experiment can alter the warranted inference compared with stopping after personal choice or first social appraisal. It must specify the opportunity inventory, what was merely unmentioned, cue and target randomization, the later informational endpoint, and the limits of attributing the effect to a subjective feeling. An observed $Z \times M$ interaction on Q would establish a bounded joint assignment effect; it would not distinguish support theory from affordance theory, nor a conscious mediator from nonconscious cue effects. An adequately precise null or a complete conventional explanation changes the publication claim: it can be an instructive synthesis of established inferential questions but cannot advertise a distinctive causal discovery.

Boundaries and limitations

This is a theoretical manuscript with hypothetical worked cases and proposed experiments. It does not report participant data showing that a large utensil was phenomenally absent from awareness, that a learning preference caused a missed book, or that a keyboard preference caused negative social judgments. Existing published work supports many constituent effects; the combined prospective sequence remains a candidate scientific function to test and compare against strong integrated predecessors.

A practical next step is to pilot the option-generation and prompted-transfer study first, because it tests the clearest distinction without requiring a full interpersonal theory. The social study can follow independently, with an explicit assessment of whether mismatch affects judgments beyond genuine contextual reasons. A subsequent integration test would ask whether the two domains share a methodologically useful distinction between a personally unconsidered alternative and an alternative considered legitimate for someone else. Each study should report its own nulls and limits.

The personal/social bridge is experimentally bounded. The crossed Z-by-M contrast concerns assignment to an earlier option cue and a later other-person choice, not a verified passage through unobserved mental stages. Equal reported preference does not imply unchanged experiential conditions; equally, an unchanged rating does not demonstrate that a new candidate was covertly acquired. The strongest matched-cue and immediate-context controls may still leave demand, learned factual relevance, or retrieval observationally equivalent. Where so, the paper must report the identified interaction and leave the process unspecified. No experimental result is reported in this theoretical draft.

9. Discussion and conclusion

The ordinary examples begin with objects and habits, but they point toward a larger phenomenon. A person can pass through an environment without experiencing every available alternative as a possible next step. Familiarity, ability, purpose, sensory response, and learned practices may make some possibilities immediately available for action while others remain peripheral or absent from current

consideration. This is not simply a decision among known options. It concerns how options become candidates in the first place.

The social consequences are especially important. Another person's preference can reveal that an alternative has meaning or utility outside one's own accustomed practice. If the observer responds with immediate dismissal, curiosity, or qualified respect, the encounter may affect whether the other person's explanation is heard. The experienced world of possibilities is not merely private: social judgments can help organize which other people and ideas become sources of information in subsequent interaction. This does not require a theory of interpersonal moral progress. It requires measuring the actual judgment and subsequent informational contact.

The broader consequence can be a history of **non-encounters**: information never sought, tools never investigated, other people's explanations never requested, or activities never imagined as reasonable. Such histories are not directly visible as missing memories in an individual participant. Controlled opportunities and experimentally altered menus make portions of them identifiable. This is where the prospective design matters: the scientist must track not only what happened but what was offered, what could feasibly be done, what became a candidate, and what additional information followed.

FutureYou's explanatory identity is thus not a theory of why small utensils, tactile keyboards, a beverage brand, or a learning method became preferred. Those familiar objects are useful because they expose a general relationship: the person already has an organization of expectations and practices; that organization helps condition what becomes experientially possible or legitimate now; and the resulting attention, action, omission, or judgment may affect the next occasion of human experience. The relationship is intelligible without assigning a unique internal route from an endpoint.

Conclusion

A larger spoon can be present without becoming a practical option. A book can be available without being considered as a route to learning. A keyboard can feel wrong for one person while making sense to another. A personal preference can be experienced as normality and sometimes used to interpret

somebody else's behavior. These phenomena are not evidence of a newly discovered preference mechanism. They are recognizable instances of how existing human organization can shape **the possibilities that become relevant within an encounter**.

FutureYou develops this relationship as a prospective scientific question: **how current organization conditions experienced possibilities, how those possibilities are interpreted for oneself and other people, and how the resulting inclusions and omissions shape subsequent encounters**. The paper grounds that question in ecological affordances, option generation, active information seeking, situated cognition, and social judgment, and specifies empirical contrasts that can distinguish candidate generation, rejection, legitimacy, action, and later information contact. Its value is to be judged by the additional explanatory and inferential work performed by that complete composition, not by assigning new names to established components or inferring invisible mechanisms from outcomes.

Use of generative AI in manuscript preparation

OpenAI ChatGPT, including GPT-6 during preparation of the journal submission draft, assisted in research development and literature exploration, manuscript organization and drafting, language editing, preliminary source checking, and document preparation. The human author originated and directed the scientific questions, evaluated the theoretical constraints and inferences, approved the substantive description of AI use, and remains responsible for the accuracy, citations, interpretation, and final submitted manuscript. AI systems are not credited as authors.

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